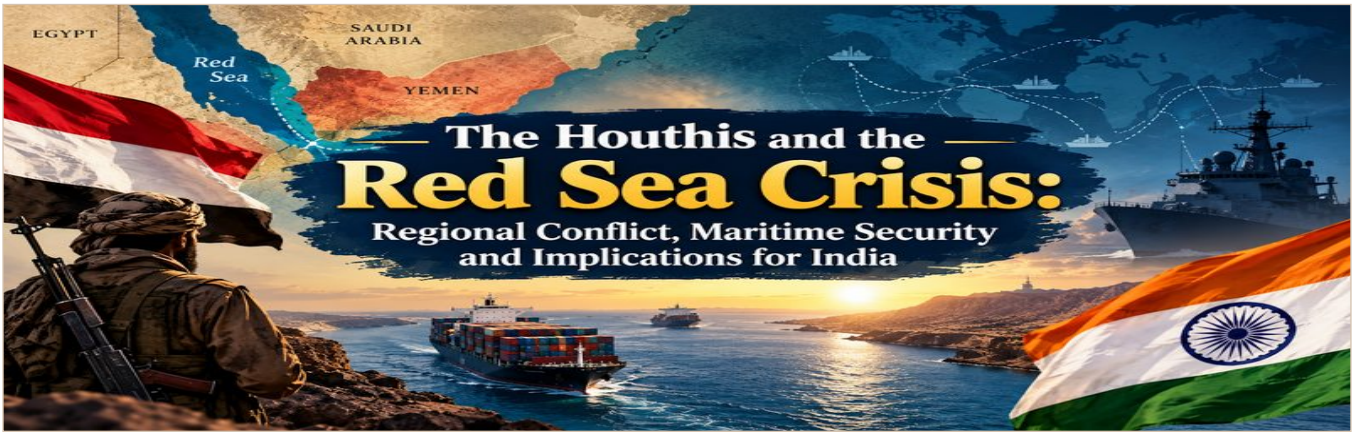


Akella Raghavendra Sir
Founder & Chief Mentor

[GS PAPER II – INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS, INTERNAL SECURITY • GS PAPER III – INDIAN ECONOMY]
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The Houthis and the Red Sea Crisis: Regional Conflict, Maritime Security and Implications for India



The article examines the Houthis' role in the Yemen conflict, their attacks on Red Sea shipping and the resulting regional security challenges. It also explores the implications for India's maritime security, international trade routes, energy supplies and strategic interests.

The Houthis and the Red Sea Crisis: Regional Conflict, Maritime Security and Implications for India

Syllabus areas:

GS Paper II – International Relations, Internal Security

GS Paper III – Indian Economy

Where: Yemen

Who: Leader — Abdul-Malik al-Houthi

What: Theme

- Maintain and expand their political and military control in Yemen.
- Oppose US and Israeli influence in the region.
- Promote their Zaydi Islamic political ideology.
- Support the Palestinian cause, which they use to support attacks on Israeli-linked targets and justify attacks on Red Sea shipping.
- Resist Saudi Arabia and other regional forces opposing them.

Formal/Official Name: Ansar Allah

Belong to: Yemen's Zaydi Shia community

Territorial Control: Sana'a, the capital of Yemen; significant parts of North and West Yemen.

Supported by: Iran, which provides weapons, training, intelligence and technical expertise.

Military Assistance: Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and Hezbollah.

International Significance: Houthi forces have attacked ships in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden, saying their actions are connected to the Israel–Gaza conflict.

Why are they fighting?

1. Yemen's civil conflict: The Houthis fought Yemen's internationally recognized government and its allies, including Saudi Arabia.

2. Saudi Arabia: Saudi Arabia intervened militarily in Yemen because it viewed the Houthi takeover as a major security threat.

3. Israel and Gaza: After the Israel–Hamas war began in October 2023, the Houthis began attacking ships they said were connected to Israel, claiming they were supporting Palestinians in Gaza.

4. United States and other countries: Houthi attacks on shipping led the US, UK and other countries to conduct military operations against Houthi targets and deploy naval forces to protect shipping.

Groups Associated with the Conflict

Group	Based in	What it is	Main focus
Houthis	Yemen	Political and armed movement	Opposition to Israel and the USA; Red Sea operations
Hamas	Gaza/Palestine	Palestinian political and armed movement	Palestinian cause; conflict with Israel
Hezbollah	Lebanon	Political party and armed group	Lebanon; opposition to Israel
Iran	Iran	Provides weapons, money, training, intelligence and political support to these groups	Support for regional allies

These groups are often described collectively as part of Iran's Axis of Resistance.

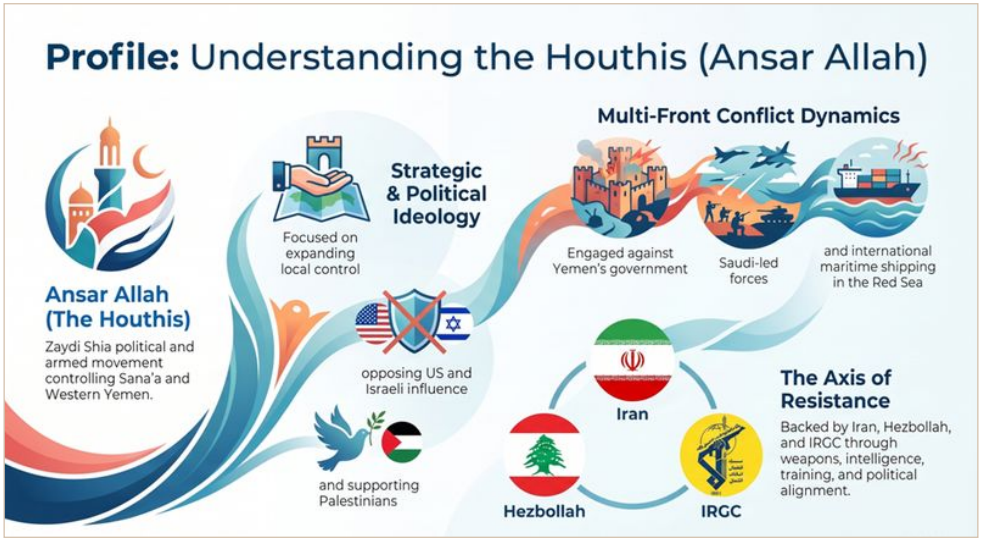
Houthis vs. Red Sea — Crisis and Conflict

Following the outbreak of the Israel–Hamas war in October 2023, the Houthis began attacking ships in and around the Red Sea.

They said their attacks were intended to pressure Israel and support Palestinians.

The attacks are against commercial shipping.

The International Maritime Organization has condemned attacks on international shipping.





The Red Sea is a major international shipping corridor connecting the Indian Ocean with the Mediterranean Sea through the Suez Canal. Ships from Asia enter through the Gulf of Aden and the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, then travel north through the Red Sea towards the Suez Canal. This route significantly reduces travel distance and time between Asia and Europe compared to the alternative route around the Cape of Good Hope. Major ports and nearby maritime regions make it an important centre for global trade and energy transportation. The strategic importance of the Red Sea is highlighted by its narrow chokepoints, where disruptions can cause shipping delays, higher freight costs and supply-chain challenges.



International shipping traffic connects major production centres, ports and markets across the world through oceans and strategically important maritime routes. Major routes link **Asia–Europe, Asia–North America, the Persian Gulf–Asia and Asia–Africa–Europe**. Ships navigate through critical **chokepoints** such as the Strait of Hormuz, Strait of Malacca, Suez Canal, Bab-el-Mandeb and Panama Canal. These routes carry containerised goods, crude oil, LNG, bulk commodities and other essential cargo. Any disruption at a major chokepoint can cause **rerouting, longer voyages, higher freight and insurance costs, and global supply-chain impacts**.



The Black Sea is a major maritime trade region connecting Eastern Europe, the Caucasus and Central Asia with global markets. Ships access the Mediterranean through the Turkish Straits, passing through the Bosporus, Sea of Marmara and Dardanelles. Major ports such as Odesa, Constan!¶ Â ædvorossiysk and Batumi support the movement of grain, oil, metals and other cargo. The Danube River also connects the Black Sea with important inland markets in Europe. Its strategic location makes it significant for international trade, energy security and regional geopolitics.